6th Ave Homes

2026 EDITION

THE DEFINITIVE HOMEOWNER'S RESOURCE

THE DFW GARAGE APARTMENT GUIDE

What Every Homeowner Should Know Before Building

Zoning basics. Real cost ranges. Timeline expectations.
And the questions to ask before you hire anyone.

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A garage apartment isn't just another real estate trend.

It's a smart way to increase property value, generate income, or create space for the people you love.

85% of DFW lots qualify for an ADU

$150K median project cost in DFW

6–9 mo average project timeline

This guide covers real costs, timelines, and zoning rules specific to Dallas–Fort Worth in 2026.

SECTION 01

Is a Garage Apartment Right For Your Property?

Before you call a builder, before you price out materials, before you even sketch something on a napkin — you need to answer a few honest questions about your property and your goals. Not every lot is a good candidate. Not every homeowner needs a full build.

THE PROPERTY CHECK

Run through this list. If you can check most of these, you're likely in good shape.

- [ ] Your lot is at least 5,000 sq ft (some cities require more)
- [ ] You have an existing garage or space for a new detached structure
- [ ] Your property isn't in a historic district with building restrictions
- [ ] You have access to utilities (water, sewer/septic, electrical) near the build site
- [ ] Your HOA doesn't prohibit accessory dwelling units (if applicable)
- [ ] Setback requirements still leave room for the structure you want
- [ ] You have a clear reason: rental income, aging parents, adult kids, home office, resale value

PRO TIP If you're not sure about setbacks, zoning, or HOA rules, don't guess. A 15-minute call with your city's planning department (or a knowledgeable builder) can save you months of wasted effort.

85%
of DFW lots qualify for an ADU

$150K
median ADU project cost in DFW

6–9 mo
average project timeline

THE GOAL CHECK

What you want the space to do shapes everything: the size, the finish level, the layout, whether you need a full kitchen or just a kitchenette, and how much you should spend.

YOUR GOAL	WHAT THAT USUALLY MEANS	BUDGET RANGE
Rental income	Full kitchen, bath, separate entrance, durable finishes	**$90K–$275K+**
Aging parent suite	ADA-friendly, single level, connected or close to main home	**$70K–$210K**
Adult child	Private entrance, kitchenette, enough separation for independence	**$60K–$180K**
Home office	Good lighting, insulation, possibly half bath, no full kitchen	**$50K–$120K**
Resale value	Permitted, well-finished, matches the home's style	**$70K–$275K+**

> *A clear goal from the start shapes the entire project. If rental income is the priority, you'll make different choices than if you're building for an aging parent. Both are valid — but they drive different budgets, timelines, and design decisions.*

That's why every good build starts with this conversation. Not with a contractor. Not with Pinterest. With honest answers to what you actually need.

Ready to check your property's potential?

The next sections will walk you through the four project types, real cost ranges, and what zoning allows in your city. Everything you need to make an informed decision before you talk to anyone.

KEEP READING →

SECTION 02

The 4 Types of Garage Apartments

Not all garage apartments are the same. There are four distinct project types — each with different costs, timelines, permitting requirements, and design constraints.

1 Garage Conversion

TYPICAL SIZE	350–600 sq ft
COST RANGE	$50,000–$120,000+
TIMELINE	8–16 weeks
BEST FOR	Home offices, guest suites, rentals on a budget
WATCH OUT FOR	Losing parking, low ceilings, foundation issues

2 Above-Garage Apartment

TYPICAL SIZE	400–900 sq ft
COST RANGE	$100,000–$250,000+
TIMELINE	4–8 months
BEST FOR	Rental income, in-law suites, long-term investment
WATCH OUT FOR	Structural reinforcement, staircase access, height limits

Most Popular in DFW: The above-garage apartment is the most common ADU type in the DFW metro — it preserves parking, maximizes lot usage, and offers the best cost-to-income ratio.

Which one is right for you?

If you already have a garage and a tight budget, start with a conversion. If you want rental income, an above-garage or detached ADU gives you the most return. If it's a guest suite or office, a casita might be all you need.

3 Detached ADU

TYPICAL SIZE	500–1,200 sq ft
COST RANGE	$120,000–$350,000+
TIMELINE	5–10 months
BEST FOR	Full rental units, multi-generational living, max privacy
WATCH OUT FOR	Lot coverage limits, utility tap fees, extended permitting

A completely separate structure on your property — its own foundation, walls, roof, utilities. Most design freedom, but also the most expensive.

4 Guest House / Casita

TYPICAL SIZE	250–600 sq ft
COST RANGE	$90,000–$275,000+
TIMELINE	4–7 months
BEST FOR	Guest suites, home offices, creative studios, Airbnb
WATCH OUT FOR	Kitchen restrictions in some municipalities, HOA rules

A smaller detached structure for guests, home office, or studio. Often no full kitchen, which can simplify permitting.

4 DISTINCT PROJECT TYPES

Each with different costs, timelines, permitting requirements, and design constraints. The right choice depends on your goals and your lot.

QUICK COMPARISON

GARAGE CONVERSION
350–600 sf | $50K–$120K+ | 8–16 wks

ABOVE-GARAGE
400–900 sf | $100K–$250K+ | 4–8 mo

DETACHED ADU
500–1,200 sf | $120K–$350K+ | 5–10 mo

GUEST HOUSE
250–600 sf | $90K–$275K+ | 4–7 mo

All cost ranges are all-in: design, permits, construction, and finishes for DFW in 2026.

SECTION 03

Real Cost Ranges for DFW (2026)

Here are real ranges based on projects we've built and priced in the DFW metro. These are all-in numbers: design, permits, construction, and finishes.

PROJECT TYPE	SIZE RANGE	STANDARD FINISH	PREMIUM FINISH
Garage Conversion	350–600 sq ft	$50K–$85K	**$85K–$120K+**
Above-Garage	400–900 sq ft	$100K–$175K	**$175K–$250K+**
Detached ADU	500–1,200 sq ft	$120K–$250K	**$250K–$350K+**
Guest House	250–600 sq ft	$90K–$200K	**$200K–$275K+**

WHAT DRIVES THE PRICE UP (OR DOWN)

- **Finish level:** Builder-grade vs. custom tile, quartz, and designer fixtures can swing costs 30–40%.
- **Plumbing scope:** A full kitchen and bathroom costs significantly more than a kitchenette or bath-only layout.
- **Structural work:** Foundation repair, roof reinforcement, or upgrades to support a second story add real money.
- **City and permitting:** Southlake and Plano permits cost more than Denton or Arlington. Impact fees vary.
- **Site access:** Tight lots, mature trees, or difficult driveways can add 5–10% to construction costs.
- **HVAC:** A mini-split system is most common for ADUs. Budget $3,000–$8,000 depending on size.

FINISH LEVEL IMPACT

Standard vs. premium finishes can swing costs **30–40%**. Custom tile, quartz counters, and designer fixtures add up fast — but they also drive rental rates and resale value higher.

HVAC Tip

A mini-split system is the most common HVAC choice for ADUs. Budget **$3,000–$8,000** depending on size. Don't let this be a surprise on your quote.

WHY DFW COSTS DIFFER FROM NATIONAL AVERAGES

Labor costs in Dallas–Fort Worth are **10–15% higher** than the national average. But land values and permitting timelines are more favorable than coastal markets. The result: you get more space and higher-quality construction for your dollar than in Austin, LA, or the Bay Area.

> *"The biggest cost surprise isn't materials — it's the gap between a builder's quote and the actual all-in number with permits, engineering, and site work."*
> — 6TH AVE HOMES PROJECT TEAM

RETURN ON INVESTMENT

6–12%
typical ROI on a well-built garage apartment in DFW

$150/sqft
average all-in construction cost for standard-finish ADUs

12–18%
annual ROI for well-located DFW ADUs

$800–$1,800
monthly rental income range

CALCULATOR Use the free cost calculator at **dfwgarageapartments.com/cost-calculator** to get a personalized estimate based on your project type, size, finish level, and city. It takes 60 seconds.

SECTION 04

Zoning Snapshot — What's Allowed in Your City

Zoning is where garage apartment dreams go to die — or get built.

Every city in DFW has its own rules. Here's a snapshot as of early 2026. This is a starting point, not legal advice.

CITY	ADUS?	KEY RESTRICTIONS
Fort Worth	YES	Most SF zones. Max 400 sq ft or 50% of primary. Must match exterior.
Dallas	YES	Allowed with SUP in some zones. Recent code updates expanding access.
Arlington	LIMITED	Permitted in certain districts. More restrictive than FW or Dallas.
Plano	RESTRICTED	Generally not allowed in standard SF zones. Variance may be required.
Frisco	RESTRICTED	Most residential zones don't permit ADUs. Limited exceptions.
Denton	YES	Generally ADU-friendly. Size limits apply. Must meet setbacks.
McKinney	LIMITED	Some zones allow with conditions. Check specific zoning district.
Southlake	RESTRICTED	Larger lots may qualify. Strict architectural review. Higher costs.

A Note on Texas SB 673

Texas SB 673 would have prohibited cities from banning ADUs statewide. It passed the Senate in April 2025 but died in the House. It's expected to be reintroduced in 2027. If it passes, many restrictions above could change. For now, your city's current code is what matters.

HOA NOTE Even if your city allows ADUs, your HOA may not. Review your CC&Rs carefully before investing in design work. Some HOAs have specific architectural standards that can add cost and timeline.

Before you break ground

Call your city's planning department and ask:

1. Is my lot zoned for an ADU?
2. What are the size and setback limits?
3. Do I need a special use permit?

Most cities answer in under 15 minutes. That one call can save you months.

FULL ZONING GUIDE

dfwgarageapartments.com/resources/adu-zoning-guide-dfw

SECTION 05

5 Questions to Ask Any Builder Before You Hire Them

Hiring the wrong builder is the most expensive mistake you can make. A builder who doesn't specialize in this type of project will miss things that cost you time, money, and headaches.

1. **"How many garage apartments or ADUs have you built in DFW?"**
   You want a number, not a vague answer. A builder who's done 10+ ADU projects knows the permitting quirks in each city and how to keep costs from spiraling.

2. **"Can you show me a permitted project similar to mine?"**
   Permits matter. Unpermitted work can kill a future sale, void insurance, and create legal liability. If a builder can't show you a permitted ADU, that's a red flag.

3. **"What's your process for handling zoning and permitting?"**
   The best ADU builders handle this for you. They know which departments to call and which forms to file. If a builder says "you'll need to handle the permits," walk away.

73%
of unpermitted ADU projects face issues at resale

3–8 wks
average permitting timeline in DFW metro cities

> *"The best builders don't just build — they guide you through every step, from zoning to final inspection."*
> — JAMEY ICE, 6TH AVE HOMES

4 **"What's included in your quote — and what's not?"**
Does the quote include design? Engineering? Permits? HVAC? Appliances? Landscaping? The gap between quoted and final price is where most horror stories live.

5 **"What does your warranty cover, and for how long?"**
A good builder offers a clear written warranty: structural (10 years), mechanical (2 years), finishes (1 year). Get it in writing before you sign.

+ **"Can I talk to a homeowner whose ADU you built last year?"**
Any builder worth hiring will say yes immediately.

The right builder won't just construct your garage apartment — they'll guide you through the entire process from zoning research to final inspection. Look for someone who's built ADUs specifically in DFW and can show you real permitted projects, not just renderings.

⚠ RED FLAGS TO WATCH FOR

- ✕ No portfolio of completed ADUs
- ✕ Can't provide permit numbers
- ✕ Asks you to handle permitting yourself
- ✕ No written warranty
- ✕ Quotes that seem 30%+ below market — they're leaving something out

The Builder Checklist

- ☑ 10+ ADU projects completed
- ☑ Can show permitted projects
- ☑ Handles zoning & permitting
- ☑ Quote is truly all-in
- ☑ Written warranty provided
- ☑ Homeowner references available

Warranty Standards to Expect

Structural	**10 years**
Mechanical	**2 years**
Finishes	**1 year**

Get it in writing before you sign.

SECTION 06

Timeline — What to Expect from Start to Finish

One of the biggest misconceptions about garage apartments is how long they take. A 600 sq ft ADU goes through the same design, permitting, and inspection process as a much larger project.

PHASE	WHAT HAPPENS	DURATION
Consultation	Site visit, feasibility assessment, initial budget range	**1–2 weeks**
Design	Floor plan, elevations, material selections, engineering	**2–4 weeks**
Permitting	City review, plan corrections, permit approval	**3–8 weeks**
Construction	Foundation, framing, MEP, insulation, drywall, finishes	**8–24 weeks**
Inspections	Multiple inspections. Final for Certificate of Occupancy.	**Ongoing**

The biggest delay? Permitting. A builder who submits clean plans the first time can save you a month or more.

TOTAL TIMELINE BY PROJECT TYPE

PROJECT TYPE	TYPICAL TOTAL
Garage Conversion	**3–6 months**
Above-Garage Apartment	**5–10 months**
Detached ADU	**6–12 months**
Guest House / Casita	**4–8 months**

3–8 wks
average permitting timeline

50+
ADU projects completed in DFW

100%
of our projects fully permitted

Your Next Step

You've got the knowledge now. You know the four types, what they cost in DFW, what your city allows, what questions to ask, and how long it takes. That puts you ahead of 95% of homeowners who start this process.

The next step is simple: have a conversation with someone who's done this before.

Schedule a Free Consultation

We'll visit your property, discuss your goals, assess feasibility, and give you a straight answer about what's possible — and what it will realistically cost. No pressure. No obligation. Just clarity.

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SCHEDULE dfwgarageapartments.com/contact

BOOK YOUR FREE CALL TODAY →

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